

conversations about money. When we are thrown together with other people from different backgrounds, and especially when circumstances conspire to change our social sphere, whether that's at university, at work or at the school gates, it's all too easy to assume that everyone else is working with the same resources that we are. After a while, Laura realized that if she wanted to feel financially secure and comfortable, she would need to focus on paying off debt and starting to save, rather than spending to keep up with her colleagues. A positive choice in itself, but Laura says that it didn't solve her money anxiety. 'Once I started to have savings, I realized how precarious my previous position was and became obsessed with having a safety net,' she says. 'This feeling has never really gone away. I constantly think about how much money is in the bank.'

'About five years ago, I burned out in my £80,000 per year corporate job and left without another to go to,' Laura reveals. 'This was terrifying, despite having about £20,000 in the bank at the time. I'm now contracting, and started on a rate of £700 a day, which is now £1,100 a day. My husband and I have around £200,000 in savings and no mortgage, but we're not doing much with it – mostly out of fear that we might make a mistake.'

I look at Laura's material situation – as you may too – and think that, on paper, it looks absolutely ideal. You might imagine that a person with that level of income and financial safety net would feel secure, but Laura still doesn't. 'I still feel